home minister Rajnath Singh, the chief of India's Intelligence Bureau (IB), Asif Ibrahim, called the NATO withdrawal the 'biggest challenge' to India's security.[67] His concerns related to increased infiltration of militants into Indian-administered Kashmir and LeT attacks on Indian missions in Afghanistan. Indeed, throughout 2015 and 2016, various attempts were made to target Indians in Afghanistan. Four Indians were killed on 13 May 2015 in an attack on the Park guesthouse (that was attacked in 2010 as well) while Indian ambassador Amar Sinha was planning a visit there, whereas a suicide attack on the Jalalabad consulate on 21 December 2015 was prevented by the NDS just before Modi's visit to Kabul. Both incidents allegedly had origins in Pakistan.[68] Another shocker came on 3 January 2016 when four militants allegedly associated to the Jaish-e-Mohammad (JeM), founded by Masood Azhar, whom India released during the IC-814 hijacking, stormed India's consulate in Mazar-e-Sharif.[69] By now, the Afghan Taliban had become less of a worry to Indian policymakers. The LeT, the JeM, and the Haqqani network, all of which operated from Pakistan's soil, and had deep links with Pakistan's security agencies, were the threat.

'A wolf in wolf's clothing'

If the Afghan Taliban was not a direct threat to India, or to Indian interests in Afghanistan, then why was New Delhi reticent about reconciling with them? India's tough political line on the Afghan Taliban gets pronounced in the light of ongoing international efforts towards reconciliation. Even more fascinating are the Afghan Taliban's continued proclamations of strong India-Afghanistan bilateral relations despite being cold-shouldered by New Delhi. Such a mismatch between the political attitudes of the Afghan Taliban and the Indian leadership towards each other was rooted in Afghanistan's domestic political equations, and stressful policy debates between the conciliators and the partisans within India. Having thrown its political weight behind Karzai, both for reasons of realpolitik and reigniting the Pashtun connection, India had no incentive to treat the Afghan insurgents at par with Kabul. But Karzai's own willingness to engage with them made it difficult even for the staunchest of partisans to boycott the insurgents. Though engagement with the Afghan Taliban was viewed as necessary